

would not alter the recommendations as they have received a flood of complaints from nuns across the state since the publication of the report. "We don't want to tamper with religious sentiments or matters of faith, but we cannot allow the denial of basic human rights to the nuns," she says. "Our recommendations have opened the floodgates of complaints from nuns about the persecution faced by this silent community," added T. Devi, a member of the Commission and a CPI(M) leader. However, the volley of protests from powerful church leaders and allegations of anti-Christian bias appear to have rattled the Government. "We will discuss the recommendations widely before implementing them," says Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan.

This issue assumes special significance in Kerala because the state has the country's largest Christian population of seven million which constitutes 22 per cent of its total population. More importantly, over 75 per cent of the priests and nuns in India who belong to different churches and congregations hail from Kerala. Several women groups and feminist theologians have periodically criticised the church's anti-woman bias and patriarchal structure. The National Consultation on Gender Justice organised by the Conference of Religious India in 2005 too had expressed deep concern over the perpetuation of gender discrimination inside the church.

Though church heads and many Christian organisations of the laity may have slammed the Commission and the state Government, many nuns and reformers have welcomed the recommendations. "It's the first time the government or the civil society has at least recognised the miseries faced by the nuns who are voiceless in the church," says a nun. "A nun's life is miserable. They are helpless when they are made to join the church. They are helpless if they leave the church as they would have no means to sustain their lives,"

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BUMPY ROAD: The nuns have a tough time ahead with the rejection of the panel's proposal by the church heads

says Joseph Pulikkunnel, noted theologian and head of Osaana, a Christian reform movement.

However, troubles for the ruling LDF Government are far from over. As if this controversy wasn't enough, there have been widespread protests by various religious groups over the contents of the new social studies textbooks for Class VII. Both Christian and Muslim organisations feel that the book attempts to promote atheism and denigrates religion. "The textbook attempts to poison young minds by instilling anti-religious feelings and atheistic attitudes," said the Kerala Catholic Bishops' Council (KCBC) in a statement demanding the withdrawal of the textbook. The KCBC has decided to observe June 30 as a Black Day to protest against the book.

Various Muslim organisations too have condemned the book. "The government does not promote any religion

using public funds. It should also desist from promoting irreligious ideas," says Syed Muhammed Turab Thangal, state president of the Sunni Students' Federation. The Muslim League has asked all religious leaders to unite in the protest against the communists' "assault" on faith and gods.

The Congress has also joined the agitation saying that the textbook attempts to glorify CPI(M)'s agitations and denigrates social reformers, the nationalist movement and the freedom struggle. "The book carries long descriptions of communist leaders but has ignored great social reformers like Sri Narayana Guru or Ayyankali or leaders like Nehru," said Hybie Eaden, president, Kerala Students Union (KSU), Congress's student wing. KSU activists who tried to barge into the state secretariat to protest against the book were beaten up by the police, which even led Union Minister for Parliamentary Affairs Vyalar Ravi to protest against the treatment metted out to them.

Later, the activists burnt several copies of the book. "We will continue the struggle until the book is withdrawn," said Chennithala. With an angry church, agitated Muslims and a hyper-active Opposition, the Kerala Government should better brace itself for a fresh spate of troubles.



"We don't want to hurt religious sentiments. But nuns cannot be denied their basic human rights."

D. SREEDEVI, CHAIRPERSON, STATE WOMEN'S COMMISSION